Perhaps I should have done so, but questions over the character of the region and its roots remain.

Lack of knowledge of the Continent, and of Eastern Europe in particular, is not helpful when trying to understand Eastern Europeans on a temporary visit to Irish or English shores. Many of the older generation of Irish simply spoke of the whole of Eastern Europe as of 'Russia' – it was an alien, pagan and wrecked land. (On one occasion in 1958, when the Yugoslav regime put a Croatian Catholic bishop on trial, the bishop of Dublin warned the faithful against attending a scheduled football match against a team from Communist Yugoslavia – with little effect though.) The new generations do not always seem to have advanced in that respect all that much, since their ventures into the Continent are too often limited to sunny *playa* and cheap booze in one of the Eastern European capitals. The Irish, of course, are not alone in their attitudes. I have met many (too many) Italians who were not aware that their country has a common border with Slovenia, and low-cost airline stag-party trips of young Brits to Bratislava are not exactly signs of an enlightened search for the truth about Eastern Europe. Even closer to Eastern Europe, in Germany and Austria, the younger generation have lost all notion of the long-established links between the German-speaking world and the Slavs (an interaction to which I devote an entire chapter) that so much characterised the history of Europe. And in the Netherlands, another of my former postings, Eastern Europeans – including diplomats – continue to struggle hard to shake off all the negative stereotypes associated with the lands beyond the invisible *new* Berlin Wall. In the meantime, at least some Central European countries have, in the eyes of the Dutch, advanced to the category of *vakantieland*, an intriguing Dutch label hailing a country's touristic qualities. And I have not even touched upon the experience with Romanian workers in the Iberian Peninsula.

In 2004, the year of the accession of the eight new member states to the European Union, I was hoping in vain for a book to be written about Eastern Europe that would mark this truly remarkable event. At least in the English-speaking world, to my knowledge, no such book appeared on the history shelves of bookshops. Tourist guidebooks, seemingly unmoved and unimpressed by the big-bang enlargement, continued to feature Greece, which lies at the continent's south-easternmost edge, under the title of Western Europe and Slovenia, which lies west of Vienna, under the Eastern